Among them was Neeti, a member of the Dandakaranya Special Zonal Committee (DKSZC). There were other high-value Maoist targets killed that day, including three divisional committee members and six area committee members.

The guns have not fallen silent in Bastar this entire monsoon season—the sheets of heavy rain have not been a deterrent for the forces as they pressed on with their 'Madh Bachao' campaign, denoting a final push to free the forested Abujhmad of Maoist presence. In the 10 days before the October 4 operation, security personnel had had three major engagements with Maoist guerrillas. On September 23, forces and Maoists exchanged fire from either side of the Chintavagu river in Sukma district. Forces claimed at least two Maoists were killed, but their bodies were carried away by the Chintavagu in spate.

More gritty battles followed, providing attritional rather than spectacular success. After a five-day-long police operation, three Maoists, including Rupesh, a DKSCZ member, and Jagdish, a divisional committee member, were killed in Narayanpur on September 26. Three days later, there was a minor retaliation by Maoists in Tarrem in Bijapur when an IED exploded, injuring five CRPF troopers on a demining operation.

The momentum finally led up to October 4 with a fortuitous turn. Highly-placed sources say the forces received credible intelligence about the presence of a large number of Maoists around Thulthuli. They were there to commemorate the raising day of company number 6 on September 21 but had extended the event to include the anniversary of the merger of Communist Party of India People's War Group and the Maoist Communist Centre (MCC) in October 2004. After suffering several setbacks, the Maoist leadership had planned this as a confidence-building measure. A fated one, as it turned out.



FIRE POWER Women commandos of the District Reserve Guard who took part in the action, Oct. 5

After a meeting on October 3, police officials put together a force from Dantewada and Narayanpur districts. The operation was led by an IPS officer posted as additional superintendent of police, Dantewada. The force, split up into small groups, entered the region through multiple ingress points to rendezvous at a hilly feature near Thulthuli. Once the Maoists' presence was confirmed, a cordon was laid around the area. The guns opened up around 1 pm. The forces used automatic weapons and under barrel grenade launchers; firing continued intermittently till 8 pm. Once the shooting was done, locals were called for identifying the bodies; two are yet to be identified. The weapons seized from the Maoists include one INSAS LMG, four AK-47 rifles, six SLR rifles, two .303 rifles and locally made guns. Only top Maoist leaders carry weapons like AKs and INSAS, thus confirming the presence of seniors among their ranks.



"THE SUCCESS OF THE OCTOBER 4 OPERATION COMES AFTER HARD WORK. THOSE INTERESTED IN PEACE IN BASTAR SHOULD ESCHEW VIOLENCE AND JOIN THE MAINSTREAM"

SUNDARRAJ P.
Inspector General of Police, Bastar

Thus far, 2024 has been the annus mirabilis in the fight against Maoists in Chhattisgarh—188 Maoist cadres have been killed in 101 operations till October 4 in Bastar division alone; in all, 194 Maoists have been killed. A total of 801 Maoists have been arrested in the state in this period, while 742 Maoists have surrendered. Among those killed by forces include Joganna, Randher, Sagar, Vinas, Jagdish and Laxmi—all non-Chhattisgarhi Maoist